

## Laggards catching up with leader

**Axis Bank in last few years done remarkable job in cleaning up its balance sheet (Net NPA declined to 0.91% in Q3FY22 from 3.4% in FY18) and preparing itself for the next phase of growth (additional provision buffer at ~2% of loans). Bank has all the right pieces, including balance loan mix (retail at 55%, Corporate at 35% and SME at 10%), stable margins (NIM stood at ~3.5%) and well capitalised balance sheet (Tier I stood at 16.5% in Q3FY22).**

### Investment Rationales

- We build in better NII (CAGR of 16% over FY22-24E) /PAT (CAGR of 43%) growth, considering the improving loan growth (CAGR of 18%) trajectory and lower Credit cost (~1.2%) on reduced NPA formation /consumption of Covid buffer, which might be impacted by higher opex (cost to assets at 2.2%) in the near-term.
- We anticipate that the bank's asset quality will remain resilient in the near to medium term, with controlled slippages and higher recoveries & upgrades, leading to an improvement in quality of earnings.
- Besides, continued improvement in the low-cost deposit base, loan mix shift towards better yielding assets and reduce share of low yielding RIDF bonds (currently standing at 3.8% of its assets) would aid smooth earnings traction.
- Axis Bank's slippages (declined to 2.6% in Q3FY22 from peak of 8.7% in FY18) as well as BB & below pool (fallen to 1.6% in Q3FY22 from peak of 7.3% of customer assets) came down meaningfully in last few years. The same was also seen in ICICI Bank, where once stress started to taper down, we saw good expansion in its price multiple.
- The high level of stress and concerns on the books had capped the valuation of Axis Bank. However, there has been material improvement in the asset quality over the last 24 months. This could lead to re-rating of the stock.

Considering all this, we expect the multiple gap between Axis Bank and other major peers such as ICICI Bank and HDFC Bank will gradually come down in the near to medium term. At CMP Axis Bank trades at 1.8x its FY24E ABV Vis a Vis ICICI Bank trades at 2.8x its FY24E ABV and HDFC Bank trades at 2.8x its FY24E ABV. **We have assigned a 'BUY' rating to Axis Bank with a price target of Rs 991, valuing the core bank at 2x FY23 ABV and subs at Rs 103.**

### Laggards are catching up with leaders

| PARTICULAR      | FY15  | FY16  | FY17  | FY18  | FY19  | FY20  | FY21  | 9MFY22 |
|-----------------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|--------|
| AXIS BANK       |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| NNPA (%)        | 0.4%  | 0.7%  | 2.1%  | 3.4%  | 2.1%  | 1.6%  | 1.1%  | 0.9%   |
| CREDIT COST (%) | 0.9%  | 1.2%  | 3.4%  | 3.8%  | 2.6%  | 3.5%  | 2.8%  | 1.0%   |
| ROA (%)         | 1.8%  | 1.7%  | 0.7%  | 0.0%  | 0.6%  | 0.2%  | 0.7%  | 1.1%   |
| ROE (%)         | 18.6% | 17.5% | 7.2%  | 0.5%  | 8.1%  | 2.3%  | 7.6%  | 12.0%  |
| ICICI BANK      |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| NNPA (%)        | 1.4%  | 2.7%  | 4.9%  | 4.8%  | 2.1%  | 1.4%  | 1.1%  | 0.9%   |
| CREDIT COST (%) | 1.1%  | 2.8%  | 3.4%  | 3.5%  | 3.6%  | 2.3%  | 2.4%  | 1.3%   |
| ROA (%)         | 1.9%  | 1.5%  | 1.4%  | 0.9%  | 0.4%  | 0.8%  | 1.4%  | 1.7%   |
| ROE (%)         | 14.3% | 11.3% | 10.3% | 6.6%  | 3.2%  | 7.1%  | 12.2% | 14.0%  |
| HDFC BANK       |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| NNPA (%)        | 0.2%  | 0.3%  | 0.3%  | 0.4%  | 0.4%  | 0.4%  | 0.4%  | 0.4%   |
| CREDIT COST (%) | 0.6%  | 0.7%  | 0.7%  | 1.0%  | 1.0%  | 1.3%  | 1.5%  | 1.0%   |
| ROA (%)         | 2.0%  | 1.9%  | 1.9%  | 1.9%  | 1.9%  | 2.0%  | 2.0%  | 2.0%   |
| ROE (%)         | 20.4% | 18.0% | 18.0% | 18.2% | 16.3% | 16.8% | 16.6% | 16.9%  |

Source: Dalal & Broacha Research, Company

| PARTICULAR          | FY15  | FY16  | FY17  | FY18  | FY19  | FY20  | FY21  | 9MFY22 |
|---------------------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|--------|
| <b>AXIS BANK</b>    |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| ADVANCES (RS BN)    | 2811  | 3388  | 3731  | 4397  | 4948  | 5714  | 6237  | 6649   |
| GROWTH (%)          | 22.2% | 20.5% | 10.1% | 17.8% | 12.5% | 15.5% | 9.2%  | 16.7%  |
| RWA TO ASSETS (%)   | 74.7% | 74.8% | 78.5% | 74.9% | 68.9% | 66.7% | 63.8% | 63.0%  |
| RETAIL LOAN MIX (%) | 39.8% | 41.3% | 45.0% | 47.0% | 49.7% | 53.4% | 53.6% | 55.3%  |
| DEPOSITS (RS BN)    | 3224  | 3580  | 4144  | 4536  | 5485  | 6401  | 7073  | 7717   |
| GROWTH (%)          | 14.8% | 11.0% | 15.8% | 9.5%  | 20.9% | 16.7% | 10.5% | 20.3%  |
| CASA (%)            | 44.8% | 47.3% | 51.4% | 53.8% | 44.4% | 41.2% | 44.9% | 44.7%  |
| C/D RATIO (%)       | 87.2% | 94.6% | 90.0% | 96.9% | 90.2% | 89.3% | 88.2% | 86.2%  |
| <b>ICICI BANK</b>   |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| ADVANCES (RS BN)    | 3875  | 4353  | 4642  | 5124  | 5866  | 6453  | 7337  | 8140   |
| GROWTH (%)          | 14.4% | 12.3% | 6.7%  | 10.4% | 14.5% | 10.0% | 13.7% | 16.4%  |
| RWA TO ASSETS (%)   | 84.3% | 84.2% | 81.0% | 72.2% | 71.3% | 69.1% | 63.8% | 63.1%  |
| RETAIL LOAN MIX (%) | 42.5% | 46.6% | 51.8% | 56.6% | 60.1% | 63.2% | 66.7% | 67.7%  |
| DEPOSITS (RS BN)    | 3616  | 4214  | 4900  | 5610  | 6529  | 7710  | 9325  | 10175  |
| GROWTH (%)          | 8.9%  | 16.6% | 16.3% | 14.5% | 16.4% | 18.1% | 21.0% | 16.4%  |
| CASA (%)            | 45.5% | 45.8% | 50.4% | 51.7% | 49.6% | 45.1% | 46.3% | 47.2%  |
| C/D RATIO (%)       | 107%  | 103%  | 94.7% | 91.3% | 89.8% | 83.7% | 78.7% | 80.0%  |
| <b>HDFC BANK</b>    |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| ADVANCES (RS BN)    | 3655  | 4646  | 5546  | 6583  | 8194  | 9937  | 11328 | 12609  |
| GROWTH (%)          | 20.6% | 27.1% | 19.4% | 18.7% | 24.5% | 21.3% | 14.0% | 16.5%  |
| RWA TO ASSETS (%)   | 71.6% | 71.5% | 74.1% | 75.2% | 74.9% | 65.0% | 64.8% | 65.4%  |
| RETAIL LOAN MIX (%) | 52.8% | 53.4% | 53.2% | 57.1% | 52.6% | 49.8% | 46.6% | 44.6%  |
| DEPOSITS (RS BN)    | 4508  | 5464  | 6436  | 7888  | 9231  | 11475 | 13351 | 14442  |
| GROWTH (%)          | 22.7% | 21.2% | 17.8% | 22.5% | 17.0% | 24.3% | 16.3% | 13.7%  |
| CASA (%)            | 44.0% | 43.2% | 48.0% | 43.5% | 42.4% | 42.2% | 46.1% | 47.2%  |
| C/D RATIO (%)       | 81.1% | 85.0% | 86.2% | 83.5% | 88.8% | 86.6% | 84.9% | 87.3%  |

Source: Dalal &amp; Broacha Research, Company

| Particular           | FY15  | FY16  | FY17  | FY18  | FY19  | FY20  | FY21  | 9MFY22 |
|----------------------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|--------|
| <b>Axis Bank</b>     |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| <b>Asset quality</b> |       |       |       |       |       |       |       |        |
| GNPA (%)             | 1.3%  | 1.7%  | 5.0%  | 6.8%  | 5.3%  | 4.9%  | 3.7%  | 3.2%   |
| NNPA (%)             | 0.4%  | 0.7%  | 2.1%  | 3.4%  | 2.1%  | 1.6%  | 1.1%  | 0.9%   |
| PCR (%)              | 66.7% | 56.9% | 57.7% | 48.2% | 59.9% | 68.7% | 71.9% | 72.0%  |
| Slippage (%)         | 1.1%  | 2.4%  | 6.1%  | 8.2%  | 3.0%  | 3.7%  | 2.9%  | 3.5%   |
| Credit Cost (%)      | 0.9%  | 1.2%  | 3.4%  | 3.8%  | 2.6%  | 3.5%  | 2.8%  | 1.0%   |

Source: Dalal &amp; Broacha Research, Company

## Q3FY22 Financial Highlights

- Axis Bank's Q3FY22 performance was supported by pick-up in loan growth (16.7% YoY/6.9% QoQ), stable margin (NIM at 3.53% vs 3.59% YoY/3.39% QoQ) and lower provisions (net credit Cost stood at 0.44% vs 3.02% YoY/ 0.54% QoQ).
- The loan growth was driven by retail segment up by 18% YoY & 6% QoQ and SME up 20% YOY & 9% QoQ. Retail segment, which accounted for 55% of advances, is ~ 80% secured, while SME book is ~96% secured with mainly working capital financing, & is well diversified across geographies and sectors. Corporate segment also showed good growth (13% YoY & 7%QoQ). 87% of corporate book is now rated A- & above with 92% of incremental sanctions in Q3FY22 being to corporates rated A- & above
- Bank's asset quality improved during the quarter, with GNPA's sequentially down by 36 bps at 3.17% and NNPA's down by 17 bps to 0.91%. During the quarter, the bank is able to contain slippages at Rs 41.47 Bn (2.5% of advances) vs Rs 54.64 Bn (3.5% of advances) QoQ.
- Bank maintained a strong PCR ratio of 72% and cumulative provisions (standard + additional other than NPA) of Rs 134.04 Bn, which translate to a standard asset coverage of 2.03% as on Dec 31, 2021.
- Operational efficiency deteriorated, with opex to average assets stood at 2.15% up by 19 bps YoY and 3 bps QoQ. The YoY increase in crore operating expenses can be broadly bucketed to (i) ~ 24% is volume linked; (ii) ~ 41% is attributable to investing for future growth of the franchise & technology; (iii) ~ 21% is attributable to collections expenses, covid expenses and statutory expenses and the balance 14% is BAU expense.

## Financials

| P&L (Rs Bn)         | Q3FY21       | Q4FY21       | Q1FY22       | Q2FY22       | Q3FY22       | YoY           | QoQ            |
|---------------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|---------------|----------------|
| Interest Earned     | 154.3        | 155.5        | 160.0        | 163.4        | 172.6        | 11.9%         | 5.7%           |
| Interest Expended   | 80.5         | 79.9         | 82.4         | 84.4         | 86.1         | 6.9%          | 2.0%           |
| <b>NII</b>          | <b>73.7</b>  | <b>75.5</b>  | <b>77.6</b>  | <b>79.0</b>  | <b>86.5</b>  | <b>17.4%</b>  | <b>9.5%</b>    |
| Other Income        | 29.3         | 46.7         | 33.6         | 38.0         | 38.4         | 31.1%         | 1.1%           |
| <b>Net Income</b>   | <b>103.0</b> | <b>122.2</b> | <b>111.2</b> | <b>117.0</b> | <b>124.9</b> | <b>21.3%</b>  | <b>6.8%</b>    |
| Opex                | 50.5         | 53.6         | 49.3         | 57.7         | 63.3         | 25.3%         | 9.7%           |
| <b>PPOP</b>         | <b>52.5</b>  | <b>68.6</b>  | <b>61.9</b>  | <b>59.3</b>  | <b>61.6</b>  | <b>17.4%</b>  | <b>3.9%</b>    |
| Provisions          | 37.6         | 32.9         | 33.0         | 17.4         | 13.3         | -64.5%        | -23.1%         |
| <b>PBT</b>          | <b>14.9</b>  | <b>35.7</b>  | <b>28.8</b>  | <b>41.9</b>  | <b>48.3</b>  | <b>224%</b>   | <b>15%</b>     |
| Tax                 | 3.7          | 8.9          | 7.2          | 10.6         | 12.1         | 224%          | 14%            |
| <b>PAT</b>          | <b>11.2</b>  | <b>26.8</b>  | <b>21.6</b>  | <b>31.3</b>  | <b>36.1</b>  | <b>223.7%</b> | <b>15.3%</b>   |
| BS (Rs Bn)          | Q3FY21       | Q4FY21       | Q1FY22       | Q2FY22       | Q3FY22       | YoY           | QoQ            |
| Net worth           | 988          | 1016         | 1039         | 1072         | 1109         | 12.2%         | 3.5%           |
| Deposits            | 6412         | 6980         | 7139         | 7363         | 7717         | 20.3%         | 4.8%           |
| Advances            | 5698         | 6144         | 6149         | 6217         | 6649         | 16.7%         | 6.9%           |
| <b>Total Assets</b> | <b>9251</b>  | <b>9868</b>  | <b>10120</b> | <b>10507</b> | <b>11131</b> | <b>20.3%</b>  | <b>5.9%</b>    |
| Ratios (%)          | Q3FY21       | Q4FY21       | Q1FY22       | Q2FY22       | Q3FY22       | YoY           | QoQ            |
| GNPA                | 3.44         | 3.70         | 3.85         | 3.53         | 3.17         | -27 bps       | -36 bps        |
| <b>NNPA</b>         | <b>0.74</b>  | <b>1.05</b>  | <b>1.20</b>  | <b>1.08</b>  | <b>0.91</b>  | <b>17 bps</b> | <b>-17 bps</b> |
| PCR                 | 79.0         | 72.4         | 69.8         | 70.2         | 72.0         | -700 bps      | 186 bps        |
| CASA                | 44.0         | 45.5         | 43.1         | 44.5         | 44.7         | 65 bps        | 20 bps         |
| Cost /Income        | 49.1         | 43.8         | 44.4         | 49.3         | 50.7         | 163 bps       | 135 bps        |

Source: Dalal & Broacha Research, Company

Exhibit 1:

| Profit & Loss Account |            |            |            |            |
|-----------------------|------------|------------|------------|------------|
| Rs in Bn              | FY21       | FY22       | FY23       | FY24       |
| Interest Earned       | 636        | 717        | 856        | 1030       |
| Interest expended     | 344        | 389        | 473        | 574        |
| <b>NII</b>            | <b>292</b> | <b>328</b> | <b>382</b> | <b>456</b> |
| Other Income          | 148        | 164        | 191        | 220        |
| <b>Net Income</b>     | <b>441</b> | <b>492</b> | <b>573</b> | <b>676</b> |
| Operating Exp         | 184        | 223        | 259        | 298        |
| <b>PPOP</b>           | <b>257</b> | <b>269</b> | <b>314</b> | <b>378</b> |
| Provisions            | 169        | 92         | 104        | 120        |
| <b>PBT</b>            | <b>88</b>  | <b>177</b> | <b>210</b> | <b>258</b> |
| Tax                   | 22         | 45         | 53         | 65         |
| <b>PAT</b>            | <b>66</b>  | <b>132</b> | <b>157</b> | <b>193</b> |

Source: Dalal &amp; Broacha Research, Company

Exhibit 2:

| Balance Sheet         |             |              |              |              |
|-----------------------|-------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|
| Rs in Bn              | FY21        | FY22         | FY23         | FY24         |
| CAPITAL & LIABILITIES |             |              |              |              |
| Capital               | 6           | 6            | 6            | 6            |
| Reserves & Surplus    | 1010        | 1136         | 1285         | 1468         |
| Deposits              | 7073        | 8190         | 9577         | 11226        |
| Borrowings            | 1429        | 1312         | 1407         | 1565         |
| Other Liabilities     | 443         | 432          | 442          | 463          |
| <b>TOTAL</b>          | <b>9961</b> | <b>11075</b> | <b>12718</b> | <b>14728</b> |
| ASSETS                |             |              |              |              |
| Cash & Balances       | 617         | 533          | 510          | 510          |
| Investments           | 2261        | 2507         | 2784         | 3154         |
| Advances              | 6237        | 7218         | 8541         | 10143        |
| Fixed Assets          | 42          | 47           | 53           | 59           |
| Other Assets          | 803         | 769          | 830          | 863          |
| <b>TOTAL</b>          | <b>9961</b> | <b>11075</b> | <b>12718</b> | <b>14728</b> |

Source: Dalal &amp; Broacha Research, Company

Exhibit 3:

| Ratios (%) | FY21 | FY22  | FY23 | FY24 |
|------------|------|-------|------|------|
| Growth     |      |       |      |      |
| NII        | 16.0 | 12.2  | 16.5 | 19.4 |
| PPOP       | 9.7  | 4.7   | 16.8 | 20.3 |
| Net profit | 305  | 100.9 | 18.9 | 22.5 |
| Deposits   | 10.5 | 15.8  | 16.9 | 17.2 |
| Advances   | 9.2  | 15.7  | 18.3 | 18.8 |
| Returns    |      |       |      |      |
| ROA        | 0.7  | 1.3   | 1.3  | 1.4  |
| ROE        | 7.1  | 12.3  | 12.9 | 13.9 |
| Efficiency |      |       |      |      |
| C/I Ratio  | 41.7 | 45.3  | 45.2 | 44.1 |
| CASA       | 44.9 | 46.1  | 46.5 | 46.7 |

Source: Dalal &amp; Broacha Research, Company

Exhibit 4:

| Ratios (%)    | FY21 | FY22 | FY23 | FY23 |
|---------------|------|------|------|------|
| Per Share     |      |      |      |      |
| BV (Rs)       | 332  | 372  | 421  | 481  |
| ABV (Rs)      | 309  | 350  | 389  | 444  |
| EPS (Rs)      | 22   | 43   | 51   | 63   |
| Valuation     |      |      |      |      |
| P/BV (x)      | 2.4  | 2.2  | 1.9  | 1.7  |
| P/ABV (x)     | 2.6  | 2.3  | 2.1  | 1.8  |
| P/EPS (x)     | 37   | 19   | 16   | 13   |
| Asset quality |      |      |      |      |
| GNPA          | 3.7  | 3.4  | 2.9  | 2.6  |
| NNPA          | 1.0  | 0.9  | 1.1  | 1.0  |
| PCR           | 72   | 75   | 63   | 60   |

Source: Dalal &amp; Broacha Research, Company

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